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Dave Valentin

Dave Valentin was born in the Bronx, New York in 1952. He was playing gigs as a percussionist by the age of 12, later taking up the flute in high school. He appeared on a number of Latin recordings in the late 1970s and was the first artist signed to GRP Records. Dave currently records for Concord and performs with his band both here and abroad.

Dave was interviewed in Scottsdale, Arizona on April 15, 2000, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe we are filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive in Scottsdale, Arizona. I'm very pleased to have Dave Valentin with me today.

DV: Pleased to be here.

MR: And I have a feeling that you're kind of an outgoing personality, from what I've seen so far. Does it help in the music world to have kind of an upbeat approach to your business?

DV: I think it helps. My family was always upbeat and we had parties on the weekends with the aunts and the uncles and music in the house and always good food and laughter. And living in the South Bronx you have to have a sense of humor, or else you get in trouble. But it's just the way I was brought up.

MR: When you were let me say five or six — you were born in '54?

DV: '52.

MR: Can I guess that the music you were hearing at that age was not the typical like rock & roll that was happening?

DV: No. No. It was Latin music, what we called Afro-Cuban rhythms, Montunos, cha cha cha, boleros, the bachanga, the charanga, Cuban music, donzonas, aragon, Tito Puente, Machito, Donyado Desontes, Tito Rodriguez, Lalupe, Celia Cruz and a lot of guitar. Tio Lapanchos, Los Motomores. So it was a combination of what we call hebajro music, which is the guitars, the old guys with the guitars on a mountain in Puerto Rico singing, and also the era of the Palladium, which my parents used to go to the Palladium, which is where everybody went to dance. We had that Battle of the Bands — Tito Puente against Tito Rodriguez, and they had to outdo each other as far as my parents told me.

MR: Yeah, that kind of healthy competition.

DV: Yeah.

MR: I guess that really spurred the music.

DV: Most definitely.

MR: Did your parents come to New York from Cuba?

DV: No my parents are from Puerto Rico, from Mayaguez. San Juan is here and Mayaguez is on the other side of the island, it was a fishing village basically. And they migrated to New York and they settled on Intervale Avenue in the Bronx, which is the original South Bronx. I grew up on Fox Street and Tiffany. And it was a wonderful New York neighborhood. It was a mixed neighborhood, you know Italians, Jews, Greeks and eventually Puerto Ricans came in, and just a whole true community where there was really no problem getting along at all.

MR: How come?

DV: Well because I think everybody brought the old values into the community. And those values I think they're similar across the board, whether you be Italian, Greek, Puerto Rican. Be nice, and do the right thing.

MR: That's a nice, great, simple concept.

DV: Yeah. And you know if I did anything — let's say I'm playing and I did something wrong. You know the Italian lady's always looking out the window on the third floor, and I'd get home and my mom would say, "So what happened?" And I said, "Nothing." "Oh you didn't break a window?" So everybody was always looking out, to make sure that we were in check. And of course we had our street games, stickball and we had slugs, which is the original spaldeen, we had pitching in, of course we had — but I think stickball was the basic call of the day, where the sewer was home plate in the middle of the street, the red car was first base, the other sewer at the end of the street was second base and the yellow car was third base. And you threw out the ball and we used to take a broom stick and we used to put it in the hole of the sewer and break it off, then you had your stick. It was a great game.

MR: Wow. Are there any rules?

DV: Yeah, hit the ball.

MR: And run as fast as you can.

DV: Hit the ball, because you wouldn't be on a team if you didn't.

MR: Does that kind of atmosphere still exist where you grew up?

DV: I don't think in the same way, no. Marbles, scelzes — you know you take a Coca Cola cap, put the penny in it, melt some wax and you had a square in the street and you had to go from square one and you had to shoot it to square two, and you had to go all the way around. And then eventually you had to get it in the middle inside a square, thirteen. Once you got to thirteen you won the game. Great game.

MR: You started out on percussion?

DV: As a percussionist. My father was a Merchant Marine. And he traveled to Brazil. He was on a luxury liner, a passenger ship, like a cruise ship. He was a first class steward in fact. And he brought me back some bongos and congas and little gourds and maracas, and I

started playing when I was five. I started playing percussion. And by the time I was ten, eleven, I was already playing in a band. I had timbales. I wanted to be like Tito Puente. So they had to pick me up and bring me back. I made like ten dollars a night. But at that time I was like a novelty playing with men, I was a little kid on timbales. So I got all the girls.

MR: Cool. Those rhythms from that kind of music, and I think I can safely say to American ears, they seem extremely complex but did they seem complex to you as a child? Or do you just absorb them?

DV: Yeah. No they were not complex at all. Because it is very complicated. You have so many rhythms, a marriage of rhythms, but they all fit together perfectly. And of course you have your clave which is [scats], and depending on the accent, it could be the other way around [scats]. So it could be three-two or two-three, depending on the way the arrangement is written. And I guess the analogy is the way you play a hi-hat where you play it on two and four. That's like a guide. We know where we're at with the clave. And then when you play a solo, to make it swing, you have to play within the clave.

MR: I guess the part that always takes me by surprise is the bass always seems to be — well not for all of the music — but a lot of times it's anticipating.

DV: Yeah it's like [scats]. And you've got all those things going on, and people are just dancing away. I just wonder — can I get a tissue just for a second?

MR: Yeah I mean I love listening to it but it seems—

DV: But it's a natural thing for me. Thank you very much. Okay, great. You can edit this. Okay. Cool.

MR: What about music in school? Were you getting anything that supported this activity?

DV: Well I was in the Glee Club in PS 39 in elementary school and I went to a junior high school called John Dwyer 133. And believe it or not we had seven music teachers. We had a chorus, we had an orchestra, we had a band, we had a jazz band, acting classes. It was just like for some reason, and Stuart Soffer who passed away, he was my teacher, and was responsible for me getting into music and art. Because I was a percussion major. I didn't play flute 'till later. But I think the teachers were really, really interested in quality education. And this was a rough neighborhood at that time. And they just did miracles there. We had an after school program, it was called Change to the Music, which eventually I worked in. I mean it was just a whole center of music. And a lot of people came out of that school.

MR: Who directed you to the flute?

DV: Well that happened, believe it or not I had no interest in the flute at all. I wanted to meet a girl. Her name was Irene. She had blonde hair and blue eyes. For me, the only girl in the South Bronx who had that. And I wanted to meet her. So I went up to her in class and

said, “Irene, can you show me something on the flute?” And she was playing flute. So she said okay. And she showed me a C major scale. And she gave me her flute and it was kind of an erotic experience because I was playing on her flute. I really started to feel, I’m getting close here. So I played the scale immediately, immediately. And she went, “Oh my — it takes about a week to get a sound. That’s great.” I’m going yeah. So I borrowed a flute from school. And I went home and I practiced boy. I bought a Herbie Mann record. Learned “The Joker” and “Comin’ Home Baby.” Came back a month later and I said I got her now, I’m going to get her now. And I played for her. And you know what, she wouldn’t talk to me ever again. She said “go away. I never want to see you. I took lessons for years and you come in a month — and get away from me” And that’s a true story. And later on of course she came to the shows and I would credit her. True story.

MR: Well you take inspiration wherever you can get it.

DV: Yes. Definitely. I’m glad because she had like five kids and she got kind of hefty. So maybe it was the right choice not to pursue it.

MR: Did your parents support you in what must have been a strong desire to make a living as a musician eventually?

DV: Well first of all my mother died when I was thirteen of cancer. So that was rough. But early on my mother told my father, “He’s going to be a musician whether you like it or not.” And my father said, “Listen, if you’re going to clean your room, do the best you can. If you’re going to be a brother, father, do the best you can. If you’re going to do the dishes, do the best you can. If you’re going to be a musician, do the best you can. And if you decide, whatever you decide, then be the best you can.” And that was his — he was a very intelligent man, world traveled. And my parents, yes, they sacrificed. They bought a piano for me early on when I was nine. They gave me piano lessons. Bought me a saxophone. And always supported me.

MR: Did you continue to play gigs as you got in your teens and so forth?

DV: Yeah. I finally made it to High School of Music and Art, again as a percussion major, and I met this guy called Ricardo Marrerro. And he started to form a group, and that was really the first time I played flute in a group. I remember my first flute solo was at a church. And I just came to look at the band and I had my flute with me and he kind of forced me to go up there and play a solo. And eventually stayed in the band, and that band recorded one album for Fania Records, so that was a long, long time ago. So that’s when it started. Besides after that I played with Colon Toledo in Manual Oquendo’s Libre, which is like the Art Blakey of Latin. It’s a school. I played in that group for seven years. And once you leave that band—

MR: You’ve graduated.

DV: You've graduated, yeah. It's a great, great, great band.

MR: Well how did the thing with — you did some study with Hubert Laws, is that right?

DV: Yeah.

MR: What a marvelous player and just his sound and everything.

DV: He's one of the greatest players of all time. And that happened, this guy Bill Fisher, he was producing an album for Herbie Mann called "Concerto in C Minor" it's a red cover with a gold flute on it. And he would let me play flute in the band, even though I was playing percussion. So he suggested that I call Hubert Laws. He gave me a music directory, a musician's directory, and I went to a pay phone. First I bought the album called "Flute By Laws," and I went to a pay phone and his number was there and I called him on a pay phone. I said, "I'm David Valentin, Bill Fisher asked me to call you and I'd like to take lessons." And he said fifteen dollars a pop, come on by. And I took lessons for six months with Hubert. That was like six years.

MR: Yeah.

DV: Yeah it was great, great.

MR: I was listening — actually I'll put something on here.

[audio interlude]

MR: I hear a bit of him in your playing, and it's okay to say that I assume.

DV: Sure, sure, it's a compliment.

MR: That tonguing and that, just, it's great.

DV: Thank you.

MR: What is he doing now?

DV: Well he plays, since he's a Jehovah's Witness, he won't play in clubs where people drink and smoke, and so he plays a lot of festivals and a lot of classical things too. He's a great classical player also. He's a really great person.

MR: Were those — I'm trying to figure how to say this. What were the toughest years for you, as far as actually trying to make a living as a musician. I hope you don't say this year.

DV: Well of course the beginning was a big sacrifice, moving in — I had a dog and a fish tank when I moved into my first apartment. And I think there was a lull when I was with GRP, maybe in the 80s, where things were disco-orientated, or whatever. And I think this quiet storm crap, I think it really damaged the music in a lot of ways. Where people think that this easy listening, like really easy listening is good music.

MR: Can I just as you to — you said "quiet storm?" Is that your own phrase?

DV: Oh no they use that on the radio, quiet storm format.

MR: Wow. I guess I'm out of touch.

DV: Or cool jazz.

MR: All right, yeah.

DV: And not to mention any names, but there's just some music where people think that's what a saxophone should sound like. And it's a no-brainer. There's no challenge in it. And I think that's damaged the music. I mean if you play good music and you play it, people will listen. It's very simple. But they are convinced that we're convinced, or the public, that they like this. Because they have no choice. There's no choice.

MR: It's almost an insult to the listener.

DV: Most definitely.

MR: It seems like this is all you can take.

DV: That's it, yeah. It's a monkey with a hammer. But people are more intelligent than that. And they would like to be challenged. You know life is just not that way. Life is up and down. And that's what makes it wonderful.

MR: How did you get with GRP? Did someone just happen to see you? Or just connections?

DV: Well I went to school with Noel Pointer and he had called me up and said he was doing a demo session, but he couldn't pay me. So he said you can bring down a tune, and we'll record it and you can keep the demo. I said all right, fine. So I brought down a tune called "Rain Storm." And after I finished the tune this guy comes out of the engineer's booth and he goes, "You know I really like that tune, do you have any more?" So I said, "Yeah I've got tons of stuff." So eventually I found out that that man was Larry Rosen. And I sent him basically my first record, all with just guitar and flute and bongos. So a few weeks later I get a call from Dave Grusin asking me would I like to make a record. And that was it. I was the first artist signed on GRP.

MR: Yeah?

DV: Yeah.

MR: Do you write at the piano?

DV: Yeah. Before it was all by hand, now I have the computer so.

MR: Okay.

DV: But yeah, everything on the piano.

MR: But is it possible to describe what gets a tune started for you?

DV: I think life. Life. Traveling. Going to Indonesia, going to Japan. Walking down the street. Smelling food. Anything can set me off. Traveling to Brazil. Just mental pictures. You come back with a lot of mental and good feelings, bad feelings.

MR: Does it usually start with the melody end of things or with the rhythmic, maybe chordal?

DV: Both ways. Sometimes I get some rhythmic stuff in my head and then the melody comes later, and then sometimes it's just the melody and the rhythm comes later.

MR: How do you like — you're with Concord now? Is it working out?

DV: Yeah. That's fine. That's very good. John Burke is a good guy. He's a musician also, just like Larry and Dave were. And that makes a big difference as opposed to a music executive that doesn't know music.

MR: Yeah. I've heard that comment a lot of times.

DV: That can be a problem. But I've lucked out. And of course I'm very difficult.

MR: You mean you're difficult to get along with?

DV: No, no, no.

MR: No I don't think so. I had to chuckle when I was listening to you and Roland Hanna this morning. It's so interesting to hear musicians at these kind of events find a common ground.

DV: Right.

MR: You mentioned some tunes to him and he said now watch out, I'm twice your age. And he'd throw some back at you.

DV: I told him watch out, I'm half your age.

MR: Do you feel at all put on the spot when you get to these things to try to be able to — I've started this question badly — but I guess I almost envision myself in that position of trying to think of oh gosh, Roland Hanna, he probably knows a zillion things, now what's in my repertoire that I can match with his. Is that a problem for you?

DV: No. I think within that timeline there's something that we know together. And then he just mentioned of course, which I forgot about, like "Autumn Leaves," and "Carnival" and all those things. So just those two tunes alone could be an hour, depending on the stretch. And then he knew "Footprints," and I showed him a little Montuno, like "Oye Como Va" type of thing.

MR: Oh yeah? Well that will add a different flavor to these things.

DV: Yeah. Because somebody told me it's much of an older concept kind of thing.

MR: Yeah. The people that come to these things have their tastes pretty much in the mainstream.

DV: Right, right.

MR: But I think they'll welcome a little — see what happens.

DV: Yeah, we'll give them a little rice and beans and see what happens. Hope they don't get gas.

MR: Is there ever a time that you've had to go out and do non-music work?

DV: I taught school for seven years, thinking I wanted to be a teacher also. But I wanted to make a change. Teaching kids was great. It's great satisfaction. But I though that I could reach more of the masses through music.

MR: Did you teach music?

DV: Yeah. And not wanting to become a role model, I became one. So I try to do the schools, I don't charge for what I call a Life Master Class, and I go to as many schools as I can during the year, just to let the kids know that we're here, that you can explore your possibilities, it doesn't matter where you come from. That's kind of the message. And be nice, and have a good time.

MR: I like that, be nice. It's such a simple concept but it's almost like we've forgotten about those kind of things.

DV: Uh huh. And of course if you was not nice, my grandmother had a remedy for that. It was this knuckle. When you wasn't expecting it, I told you to BE NICE!. Okay, okay, grandma. Out of the blue. And she also taught me Spanish, my grandma. She talked perfect English but she wouldn't speak to me in English. So I said, "Grandma can I have this?" She says, "I no understan." [Speaks Spanish]. So that was a good thing.

MR: So your parents didn't speak Spanish in the house?

DV: No they did. Because after my mom died my father went back to sea, I lived with my grandma. She was a wonderful lady.

MR: Any siblings? You have brothers and sisters?

DV: Yes. I have two brothers, one passed away, both named Jorge like my father. In fact one of my brothers named me Dave. I said thanks. Another Jorge in the family.

MR: What do you see in the future for your own goals?

DV: Well I want to be a drug dealer now?

MR: Yeah.

DV: It's a wonderful profession.

MR: Okay. Got the corner staked out?

DV: No I think the future is to continue to play and explore my possibilities as much as I can, and write music and get to meet more and more musicians and play in different contexts with the music. Like I just was with McCoy Tyner, which was a great experience to play with recording, he was doing a Latin jazz thing. He called me, I says, "Hello?" "Yeah, Dave?" "Yes." "This is McCoy Tyner." "Yeah, right. Stop messing around, who's this? "It's McCoy Tyner." "Really?" "Yeah." I'm starting this Latin jazz thing, would you like to play?" Boom. And we did many gigs together. He's a great player. Things like that. One day I'm in Guadalupe and Tito Puentes — they all kind of speak alike you know. "You know Dave" — he's more animated. "I want to do something new. I want the old guy to play with the young guys. And it's going to be called Tito Puentes Golden Latin Jazz All-Stars. You want to be my musical director?" And I go, "Yeah, does it pay more money?" He says, "No." I said, "I'll take the job." It did pay more money. So that's another thing.

MR: I overheard you telling a humorous story about him at the Grammy awards.

DV: Yeah. He thought he was not going to win. And he was downstairs and he was like that going, "I ain't going to win nothin. All the Cubans are going to win." And he actually won. And to make it short, and he told me, "And I had to run down five miles to get my Grammy." They put me in the tenth tier. He walked out very sad out of the hotel and came back like a little kid. And I'm glad, I said, "Pop, I'm glad you won." Because he was depressed he was not going to win, he just went there because Santana, you know, all that stuff.

MR: There seems to be a pretty big surge in popular music with Latin influences.

DV: Yeah.

MR: Does that impact at all on what you do?

DV: Yeah I think it has made people more aware of the rhythms and different contexts. I think it's a good thing. Whether it's because of the Buena Vista or — I think it helps everyone.

MR: And you got to play with Herbie Mann eventually.

DV: Oh Uncle Herbie, yeah. Another guy. We're on stage, and he talks like that too. He talks the same way which is with a little different inflection. So we're playing a tune and he's at that side of the stage and I'm over here. And he walks at me. So I think he's going to say look we're going to go to A, we go to the bridge and we take it out. So he goes, "Dave" right when the band is playing. He goes, "What we should do, we should make tee shirts and sell them and then let's do a record together and we'll make some money." And walked away. It was actually his idea to do "Two Amigos."

MR: Did you get the tee shirts?

DV: No.

MR: Did you make some money?

DV: No. But it was a great idea. Uncle Herbie. Uncle Herbie.

MR: I'm interested to listen this afternoon, whenever it happens, if you do get into some Latin styles, just to see how the bass players and the drummers—

DV: We're going to try. I think they're going to have a conga player there so that may add a different injection of stuff, we'll see.

MR: Great. What was the worst experience you've had playing music up to date. Is that possible to dredge anything like that up?

DV: Boy there's so many.

MR: Have you had any disasters on the road? I mean doing traveling around the world?

DV: I think, no, not really. I think one of the worst times I had was breaking somebody's passing away to one of the band members. I think that was difficult for me. I had to tell Bill O'Connell that a fax came under my door that his father had passed away. And then I had to go and tell him. And I just broke down. Because my father had passed away so it just brought back — so I'm out of it. And Bill O'Connell says, "Dave it's okay, are you

all right?" He was comforting me, because I guess he was expecting it but I wasn't. But I think that's something that stands out in my mind.

MR: How about one of the greatest things you've done so far.

DV: Oh I'd say just being with this band for such a long time. Bill O'Connell, Robby Ameen, Lincoln Goines and Milton Cardona. I believe in family affair. They've been with me for more than fifteen years. And I really like that. They can do everything. But we're actually a family. You know a change here, if one can't make a gig, but I like that feeling and it's extremely comfortable.

MR: And it's not that prevalent in the music business anymore to have a group that hangs together like that for so many years.

DV: Exactly. And the other analogy is that being with GRP for eighteen years. That's kind of strange too. But after a while, I think I was the mentsh of the company I guess they call it. They really, being the first artist signed, and I was going out with Angela Bofill at the time too, and she was the second artist signed. They made tons of money with her. They were very happy. And after a while I would go to Vladius and go, "Am I making another record?" He'd go, "Yeah." "So after, do you want to hear the masters?" "No." "Okay. Put it out."

MR: You mean he gave you just free reign to go out and do the thing?

DV: Yeah. Here it is.

MR: Wow.

DV: Great.

MR: Have you ever had — well apparently not but I was curious if you've ever had producers who wanted you to like include something because they thought it would help your sales.

DV: Well with the disco thing, there was one album called "Flute Juice" and I think a review came in called "it should be called 'Prune Juice.'" That's the last time I did that. And I told Vladdy I'm not going to make another record like this. The next record was "Kalahari," and that was one of the best records I've done. I said please — because it was actually his suggestion because he thought — the sales — he thought that might be a good idea to do some discoish kind of thing. But it didn't work out. But at least he learned quickly. I said just let me produce, Larry, you just sit behind the desk.

MR: Did Dave ever get in on the — did he play on —

DV: Yeah he played on some of the records, great, great, great, great man. In fact we just did that remake for the "West Side Story" also, where it was just piano and flute. And we did "I Feel Pretty" but with a whole new twist to it, which eventually had an Afro-Cuban thing but in seven-four. So it's [scats]. And we did it at Carnegie Hall, we did that. And there's a lull just before he starts his piano solo and he's ready to go, and people start applauding. And they're applauding, they're applauding. So Dave gets up and says "the

tune is not over yet." And then I said, "Let me translate that in Spanish," and I told the audience, "we not finni ye." He fell off the piano. He couldn't even start playing again. "We not finni ye, we tell you okay?"

MR: Oh man, that's funny.

DV: That's Carnegie Hall, man. Tuxedos. "We no finni ye."

MR: See the classical audience would know not to – to wait until the suite is over.

DV: Right.

MR: So you've been from the Bronx to Carnegie Hall?

DV: Yes.

MR: That's saying a lot.

DV: That's not bad. That's not bad. I have to thank God for everything that's happened to me. And a lot of the old timers, Mario Bauza, says, "You know what? If you think it's that bad, it's really not. And if you have faith, intelligence and a sense of humor you can overcome anything." So those are good advice, for everyone.

MR: Well it sounds like a good place to wrap this up.

DV: And the other one of course: "If you're tired, stay home."

MR: Yeah, who said that?

DV: That's Tito Puente.

MR: Okay.

DV: And if you're drunk, don't drink. What's the matter with you. Jesus. Very simple life rules.

MR: Yeah. And be nice.

DV: And be nice, and behave.

MR: All right. Well I'll be listening later today and I hope you have a great weekend, and maybe ten years from now we'll do another one and see if you're still nice.

DV: Thank you. All right.